3. Sufism in India

The advent of Sufis to India dates back to the Arab conquest of Sind. It gained prominence in the 10th and 11th centuries during the reign of the Delhi Sultans. Sufism adopted many native Indian concepts such as yogic postures, music and dance. Sufism found adherents among both Muslims and Hindus.

Sufism: The word Sufi takes its origin from *suf,* meaning wool. The Sufis wore course garments made of wool and hence they were called Sufis. Sufism was basically Islamic but was influenced by Hindu and Buddhist (Mahayana) ideas. It rejected the stringent conduct code of the *ulemas.* Sufis lived in hermitages akin to monasteries and functioned outside society.



Sufis in medieval India were divided into three major orders. They were Chisti, Suhrawardi and Firdausi. Moinuddin Chishti made Chisti order popular in India. He died in Ajmer (1236) and his resting place is in the Ajmer Sharif Dargah in Ajmer, Rajasthan. The best known Sufi sage of the early medieval period was Nizamuddin Auliya of the Chishti order, who had a large number of followers among the ruling class in Delhi. Poet Amir Khusru was one of its distinguished followers. Suhrawardi order was founded by an Iranian Sufi Abdul-Wahid Abu Najib. The Firdausi order was a branch of Suhrawardi order and its activities were confined to Bihar.

4. (a) Kabir



Kabir

Kabir, came under the influence of Varanasi-based Saint Ramananda. He accepted some Hindu ideas and tried to reconcile Hinduism and Islam. However, it was the Hindus, and particularly those of the lower classes, to whom his message appealed. Kabir believed that God is one and formless, even though different religious sects give him different names and forms. He opposed discrimination on the basis of religion, caste and wealth. He also condemned meaningless rituals. Kabir's verses were composed in Bhojpuri language mixed with Urdu. The Kabir's *Granthavali* and the *Bijak* contain collections of Kabir's verses.

(b) Guru Nanak

Early Life: Guru Nanak, born in a village near Lahore in 1469, showed interest in religious discussions with other saints right from his early childhood. His parents were keen to involve him in worldly life. But he was inclined towards spiritualism. He visited many holy places and finally settled in Kartarpur near Lahore. He died there in 1539. To mark the 550th birth anniversary of Guru Nanak, a corridor constructed by the Indian government that links the Nanak shrine in Gurdaspur with Gurudwara Darbar Sahib at Kartarpur in Pakistan.